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Syllabary

66 languages

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In the **linguistic** study of **written languages**, a **syllabary** is a set of **written symbols** that represent the **syllables** or (more frequently) **morae** which make up **words**.

A symbol in a syllabary, called a **syllabogram**, typically represents an (optional) **consonant** sound (simple **onset**) followed by a **vowel** sound (**nucleus**)—that is, a CV (consonant+vowel) or V syllable—but other **phonographic** mappings, such as CVC, CV- tone, and C (normally nasals at the end of syllables), are also found in syllabaries.^[*citation needed*]

Types [edit]

A **writing system** using a syllabary is *complete* when it covers all syllables in the corresponding spoken language without requiring complex **orthographic / graphemic** rules, like **implicit codas** (<C₁V> → /C₁VC₂/), **silent vowels** (<C₁V₁+C₂V₂> → /C₁V₁C₂/) or **echo vowels** (<C₁V₁+C₂V₁> → /C₁V₁C₂/). This loosely corresponds to *shallow* orthographies in alphabetic writing systems.^[*citation needed*]

True syllabograms are those that encompass all parts of a syllable, i.e., initial onset, medial nucleus and final coda, but since onset and coda are optional in at least some languages, there are *middle* (nucleus), *start* (onset-nucleus), *end* (nucleus-coda) and *full* (onset-nucleus-coda) true syllabograms. Most syllabaries only feature one or two kinds of syllabograms and form other syllables by graphemic rules.

Syllabograms, hence syllabaries, are *pure*, *analytic* or *arbitrary* if they do not share graphic similarities that correspond to phonic similarities, e.g. the symbol for *ka* does not resemble in any predictable way the symbol for *ki*, nor the symbol for *a*. Otherwise, they are *synthetic*, if they vary by onset, rime, nucleus *or* coda, or *systematic*, if they vary by all of them.^[*citation needed*] Some scholars, e.g., Daniels,^[1] reserve the general term for analytic syllabaries and invent other terms (**abugida**, **abjad**) as necessary.

Languages using syllabaries [edit]

Languages that use syllabic writing include **Japanese**, **Cherokee**, **Vai**, the **Yi languages** of eastern Asia, the English-based **creole language Ndyuka**, **Xiangnan Tuhua**, and the ancient language **Mycenaean Greek** (**Linear B**).^[2] The **Cretan Linear A** and its derivative **Cypro-Minoan** are also believed by some to be syllabic scripts, although as they remain undecoded, this has not been confirmed.

Chinese characters, the **cuneiform script** used for **Sumerian**, **Akkadian** and other languages, and the former **Maya script** are largely syllabic in nature, although based on **logograms**. They are therefore sometimes referred to as *logosyllabic*.

The contemporary Japanese language uses two syllabaries together called **kana** (in addition to the non-syllabic systems **kanji** and **romaji**), namely **hiragana** and **katakana**, which were developed around 800 CE. Because Japanese uses mainly CV (consonant + vowel) syllables, a syllabary is well suited to write the language. As in many syllabaries, vowel sequences and final consonants are written with separate glyphs, so that both *atta* and *kaita* are written with three kana: あった (*a-t-ta*) and かいた (*ka-i-ta*). It is therefore more correctly called a ***moraic*** writing system, with syllables consisting of two moras corresponding to two kana symbols.

Languages that use syllabaries today tend to have simple **phonotactics**, with a predominance of monomoraic (CV) syllables. For example, the modern **Yi script** is used to write languages that have no diphthongs or syllable codas; unusually among syllabaries, there is a separate glyph for every consonant-vowel-tone combination (CVT) in the language (apart from one tone which is indicated with a diacritic).

Few syllabaries have glyphs for syllables that are not monomoraic, and those that once did have simplified over time to eliminate that complexity. For example, the Vai syllabary originally had separate glyphs for syllables ending in a coda (*don*), a long vowel (*soo*), or a diphthong (*bai*), though not enough glyphs to distinguish all CV combinations (some distinctions were ignored). The modern script has been expanded to cover all moras, but at the same time reduced to exclude all other syllables. Bimoraic syllables are now written with two letters, as in Japanese: diphthongs are written with the help of V or hV glyphs, and the nasal codas will be written with the glyph for *ŋ*, which can form a syllable of its own in Vai.

In **Linear B**, which was used to transcribe **Mycenaean Greek**, a language with complex syllables, complex consonant onsets were either written with two glyphs or simplified to one, while codas were generally ignored, e.g., *ko-no-so* for Κνωσός ***Knōsos***, *pe-ma* for σπέρμα ***sperma***.

The Cherokee syllabary generally uses dummy vowels for coda consonants, but also has a segmental grapheme for /s/, which can be used both as a coda and in an initial /sC/ consonant cluster.

Difference from abugidas [edit]

The languages of **India** and **Southeast Asia**, as well as the **Ethiopian Semitic languages**, have a type of **alphabet** called an ***abugida*** or *alphasyllabary*. In these scripts, unlike in pure syllabaries, syllables starting with the same consonant are largely expressed with **graphemes** regularly based on common graphical elements. Usually each character representing a syllable consists of several elements which designate the individual sounds of that syllable.

In the 19th century these systems were called *syllabics*, a term which has survived in the name of **Canadian Aboriginal syllabics** (also an abugida).

In a true syllabary there may be graphic similarity between characters that share a common consonant or vowel sound, but it is not systematic or at all regular. For example, the characters for *ka ke ko* in Japanese **hiragana** – か (け こ – have no similarity to indicate their common /k/ sound. Compare this with **Devanagari** script, an abugida, where the characters for *ka ke ko* are क के को respectively.

Comparison to alphabets [edit]

English, along with many other Indo-European languages like German and Russian, allows for complex syllable structures, making it cumbersome to write English words with a syllabary. A "pure" English syllabary would require over 10,000 separate glyphs for each possible syllable^[3] (e.g., separate glyphs for "half" and "have"). However, such pure systems are rare. A workaround to this problem, common to several syllabaries around the world (including **English loanwords in Japanese**), is to add a **paragogic** dummy vowel, as if the **syllable coda** were a second syllable: *ha-fu* for "half" and *ha-vu* for "have".

The **Korean** script **Hangul** has been described as a syllabic alphabet as it combines the features of alphabetic and syllabic writing systems.^{[4][5]} Korean letters are written in syllabic blocks with the alphabetic letters arranged in two dimensions. For example, **Seoul** is written as 서울, not 새 l o t e r l.^[6]

See also [edit]

- List of syllabaries

References [edit]

- ↑ Peter Daniels, 1996. "The Study of Writing Systems", p. 4. In: Daniels & Bright, *The World's Writing Systems*.
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"Among the earliest known purely syllabic scripts probably is Linear B, used for writing Mycenaean Greek from the middle of the second millennium BCE."
- ↑ Chris Barker. "How many syllables does English have?" . *New York University*. Archived from the original on 2016-08-22.
- ↑ *Pae, Hye K.* (1 January 2011). "Is Korean a syllabic alphabet or an alphabetic syllabary". *Writing Systems Research*. **3** (2): 103–115. doi:10.1093/wsr/wsr002. ISSN 1758-6801. S2CID 144290565.
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 V • T • E 	Writing systems	[hide]
	Index of language articles	
Overview	Language • History of writing • History of the alphabet • Graphemes • Scripts in Unicode	
Lists	Writing systems • Languages by writing system / by first written account • Ancient languages corpuses by size • Undeciphered writing systems • Creators of writing systems	
Types	Abjads • Abugidas • Alphabets • Featural • Ideogrammic • Logographic • Numeral • Phonogrammic • Pictographic • Semi-syllabaries • Shorthand • Syllabaries	
Current examples	Arabic • Canadian syllabics • Chinese • Devanagari • Hangul • Kana • Latin • Mongolian	
Related topics	In Africa • In Southeast Asia	
 V • T • E 	Types of writing systems	[show]
Category: Syllabary writing systems		